

mandatory flowers," grins Ajay Vir Singh of Dhillon Aviation, whose single four-seater Bell Jet Ranger now counts brides and grooms on its list of frequent fliers like politicians and business executives. In Gurgaon, farmers are ceding land to the National Capital Region's fast expanding urban sprawl and using a tiny bit of the proceed to fund these flying *dolis*. Newly-baptised by prop wash and the astonishing sight of a bride and groom ascending to the skies in front of goggle-eyed gawkers, obscure villages like Ullawas and Fazilpur have suddenly become buzzwords in the rural marriage grapevine.

**W**hen a promised helicopter doesn't materialise, as it happened in Badshahpur, a village of over 14,000 bordering Gurgaon, it can lead to social angst. Billoo Yadav, 28, sits sullen and bleary-eyed on a sofa, sipping sugary tea. His brother, Inderjit, was married just three days earlier but the helicopter did not show up because the company returned his cheque, saying it had to send its machine for electioneering in Gujarat. "I'm going to drag the charter company to court," he fumes. "We had told everyone in the village. Can you imagine the shame?" he sighs, three chunky gold rings glinting furiously on his right hand. Land prices here have skyrocketed from Rs 5 lakh an acre to over Rs 5 crore in less than a decade. The scion of wedding organisers, Yadav Tent House, like many other families in nearby villages has made crores selling ancestral lands (Billoo won't say how much), so a few lakh is small change for them to make an extreme impact on people.

It's not just hiring the machine, though. Hidden costs include creating and clearly marking helipads in both the bride and the groom's village and ensuring there are fire tenders, ambulances and security personnel standing by at both locations. The process of dealing with the slow grinding bureaucracy, chiefly taking permissions from the district magistrate, begins two months in advance. "I probably spent more time and money on the infrastructure than on chartering of the actual chopper," says one wedding planner. Yet, the reason why helicopter weddings are primarily



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### ROTOR COSTS

**What it takes to hire a helicopter for your wedding**

**4-SEATER: Rs 55,000 per hour**

**5-SEATER: Rs 75,000 per hour**

**6-SEATER: Rs 80,000 per hour**

a rural fad is the fact that it is far easier to land a chopper without hassles in village clearings and playgrounds than in the multiple obstructions of the urban jungle.

It is a niche business market, but still growing. "There are around a dozen helicopter operators in north India, each rents out one helicopter for at least three weddings each year," says a charter operator. The busiest months are the wedding season ones—between November and February.

The fad began nearly two years back, in Punjab, the capital of conspicuous consumption before it spread to Haryana and Uttar Pradesh. Punjabi NRIs began using helicopters to displace the sleek black Lincoln and Mercedes limousines as must-haves for the weddings, treating villagers to the sight of sniffing brides boarding choppers and waving goodbyes.

When Harmel Singh Dhillon, the bridegroom from Tashpur, a sleepy village in Kapurthala, landed at a fancy

**ON CLOUD NINE:** Harmel Dhillon with his bride after their flight home

marriage palace in Ludhiana, Punjab in a hired chopper last year, it became quite a sensation in the city. For 23-year-old Dhillon, it was a ride into instant fame. "It was my uncle's wish to see me leading the *baraat* in a chopper," said Dhillon whose uncle, New Jersey-based petrol pump magnate Harbans Singh Dhillon, spent Rs 4.5 lakh on hiring the helicopter from a Delhi-based firm. Long after the dust had settled on the high-flying wedding, which status-conscious Ludhiana had never seen, its sheer novelty continues to wow the city's society. "It's a once-in-a-lifetime expense to live up your dreams," said Dhillon, who arrived at the wedding venue an hour before the *baraat* travelling by road could catch up with him. It was the first flight for his 19-year-old bride Roopinder Kaur, daughter of a farmer from Kurukshetra, who had only seen helicopters in the skies flying over her village. Dhillon's marriage is only an example of the growing trend fuelled by the expatriate extravagance back home. Increasingly, the NRIs are splurging lavishly on marriages to make a statement of their riches among the natives. Clearly they are not the only ones who can afford to do so.

**with Ramesh Vinayak**